

A few questions about Japanese

Naoshi, September 2026. Seven questions. About 20 minutes.

Please read first

This is **not** the official review. Nothing here is a test. Nothing waits for your answer.

"I am not sure" is a good answer. It tells us the explanation is weak.

Our app teaches Japanese to English speakers. It explains why Japanese works the way it does. A computer wrote these explanations. We checked the grammar rules in dictionaries. We cannot check how the Japanese sounds. Only you can do that.

The same question, seven times:

Would a Japanese person really say this, in this situation?

Or is this only a textbook answer?

Short answers are fine. "Yes", "no", or "not sure" is enough. If something is wrong, please say so. "Too strong" or "not natural" helps us a lot.

1. Levels of politeness

We teach five ways to ask for a pen. We tell learners to choose the level by **who they are talking to** — not by how much they want the pen.

Level	Japanese	We teach it for
1	ペン、貸して。	a close friend
2	ペンを貸してくれる？	a friend, a little softer
3	ペンを貸してもらえますか。	a coworker — "normal at work"
4	ペンをお貸ください。	formal
5	ペンをお貸しいただけないでしょうか。	someone much higher than you

Questions:

- Is the order correct?
 - Is level 3 normal between coworkers?
 - We tell learners: **too polite is also a mistake**. We say level 5 to a friend sounds sarcastic, or sounds like you are angry. Is this true?
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2. ～くせに

We call this **the rudest way to say "even though."** We say it is like **のに**, but with contempt.

知っているくせに、教えてくださいませんでした。

子どものくせに、生意気です。

We tell learners: **read it, but do not use it.**

We also say **子どものくせに** is **never kind**. We say it means you are only a child, so how dare you.

Questions:

- Is "contempt" correct? Or does くせに have softer uses too?
 - Can **子どものくせに** be said in a warm or joking way between close people?
 - Is "read it, do not use it" the right advice?
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3. ～わけだ and ～わけではない

We say that most English books explain **わけだ** wrongly. They call it a reason. We say it is not a reason. We say it is a **conclusion** — the listener already knows the reason, and now they understand.

十年住んでいるんですか。道理で日本語が上手なわけですね。

電車が止まっていたんです。だから遅れたわけです。

For **わけではない**, we teach that it says **"that is not the conclusion"** — not "that is not true."

全部わかったわけではありません。

We teach this as: I did not understand everything.

We say it does **not** mean: I understood nothing.

Questions:

- Is "conclusion, not reason" correct? Or are we making it too complicated?
 - We say **わけだ cannot start a conversation**. Is that true?
 - Is our meaning for **全部～わけではありません** correct?
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4. にあたって and に際して

We teach both as formal. We say **にあたって** is used a little **earlier** — for something that is about to begin.

面接を受けるにあたって、会社のことをよく調べた。

ご契約に際して、以下の書類が必要です。

Two things we are not sure about:

- **We say both are wrong for bad events.** We say 事故にあたって is wrong.
- **We say に際して is too formal for small daily things.** We say 昼ご飯に際して sounds like a joke.

Questions:

- Are those two points correct?
 - Is the difference between にあって and に際して clear to you? Or are they almost the same?
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5. ～かねます

We teach this as a **polite way to refuse**. We say you hear it from shop and office staff. We teach かねない as the opposite meaning: it might happen (and it is something bad).

その質問にはお答えしかねます。

このままでは、大きな問題になりかねない。

Questions:

- Do staff really say お答えしかねます and 分かりかねます? Or is it too formal now?
 - We say かねない is **never used for good things**. We say 合格しかねない is wrong. Is that always true?
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6. Saying no without いいえ

This is the most important question. Please be direct with us.

This lesson is about how Japanese people refuse things. Many foreign books explain this badly. We may also be wrong.

We do **not** say "Japanese people never say no." We say something different:

- Japanese people say no often. But they usually do not use the word いいえ.
- いいえ is for **facts**. 「これはペンですか」「いいえ、鉛筆です」. We say people do not use いいえ to refuse a request or to disagree.
- We say these are the real ways to refuse:
 - 「明日はちょっと…」 — the sentence is not finished, and that is the refusal
 - 「難しいですね」 — this means no
 - 「考えておきます」 or 「検討します」 — sometimes real, often no
- We give a reason: this way, **nobody has to hear the word no**. The person who asked is not embarrassed.

Questions:

- Is anything here too strong, or too confident?
 - Is 難しいですね really a clear no?
 - Is our reason correct? Or is it a foreign idea that is too simple?
 - **Is there anything here you would delete?**
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7. Two rules — quick yes or no

We teach these to beginners as rules with **no exceptions**.

- **まえに never uses past tense.** Always 寝るまえに, even about the past.
- **ながら needs one person doing both actions.** For two people, we say you must use ~ている間に.

Are both always true? Or should we make them softer?

Thank you

If you answer only one question, please answer **number 6**. Books cannot tell us that one. Only a Japanese speaker can.

Thank you very much. This helps us a lot.